Clean Inside and Out

Matthew 23:23-28 (KJV)

Scripture

Matthew 23:23-28

23 Woe unto you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! for ye pay tithe of mint and anise and cummin, and have
omitted the weightier matters of the law, judgment, mercy, and faith: these ought ye to have done, and not
to leave the other undone. 24 Ye blind guides, which strain at a gnat, and swallow a camel. 25 Woe unto you,
scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! for ye make clean the outside of the cup and of the platter, but within
they are full of extortion and excess. 26 Thou blind Pharisee, cleanse first that which is within the cup and
platter, that the outside of them may be clean also. 27 Woe unto you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! for
ye are like unto whited sepulchres, which indeed appear beautiful outward, but are within full of dead
men's bones, and of all uncleanness. 28 Even so ye also outwardly appear righteous unto men, but within ye
are full of hypocrisy and iniquity.

Outline

1. Do not major on minors

The weightier matters of the law are judgment, _____, and faith.

They strain out a gnat and swallow a _____.

Read: Matthew 23:23-24; Micah 6:8; Luke 11:42

2. Clean the inside first

Cleanse first that which is _____ the cup.

Only God can give us a clean _____.

Read: Matthew 23:25-26; Psalm 51:10; Ezekiel 36:26

3. Do not be a whitewashed tomb

Ye outwardly appear _____ unto men.

The opposite of hypocrisy is honest _____.

Read: Matthew 23:27-28; 1 Samuel 16:7; 1 John 1:8-9

Discussion questions

1. What "gnats" do churches sometimes strain out while swallowing "camels"?

2. Why is it so easy to care more about how we look than about our hearts?

3. How can a church become a place where people do not need to pretend?

4. If only God can clean the inside, what is our part?

This week

Pray Psalm 139:23-24 every day this week: "Search me, O God, and know my heart." Ask God to show you one area where your outside and inside do not match. Confess it to him, and if it would help, to a trusted Christian friend.